

To Simpler Times

Cut through all the madness to generate reports quick and easy with Excel's PivotTables

Nimish Chandiramani

If you've ever heard of PivotTables, you either swear by them or they've successfully baffled you into not going near them. For a feature that does what it does, the PivotTable is probably Excel's best-kept secret—this despite the fact that it's the easiest way to generate reports of your data without knowing even a line of VB code. You don't even need to know what VB stands for to create one! (*Visual Basic, incidentally*)

We'll be using Office 2007 for this article—most of the features carry over from Office 2003, but the new ribbon on Office 2007 exposes a lot more features that you can use with PivotTables, so you might find something new even if you've been using them for a while.

Life Before The Pivot

Imagine this rather innocuous table that looks at the sales of five products in three cities, by three salesmen. We'll be using this as a reference, but the principles will apply to any data that fits the "pivot-able" bill (we'll come to that in a bit).

Gauging a salesperson's performance in Mumbai, for example, is quite simple. You first need to apply a data filter and select Mumbai under City, then select each salesperson one by one from the respective column. Select the Units Sold column, and Excel gives you a total at the bottom right of your screen. Repeat for each salesperson, then repeat for each city. Ten rows of data, no code, fifty-odd mouse-clicks. In the real world, people need to deal with hundreds, even thousands of rows of data, perhaps fifty cities, a hundred salespeople and a whole lot more than just five columns. They also need to print out summary reports—something you can't achieve by the method above. Will they really resort to such ridiculousness?

Of course not. They will use code to generate their summaries—through judicious use of the SUMIF() and COUNTIF() functions and through macros meticulously crafted in long hours of overtime, impressing all and sundry and generally feeling good about their expertise. And then there are those who will use PivotTables—no code, no million mouse-clicks, same result.

Gearing Up

Before we get down to creating and using PivotTables, you need to know whether you're going to benefit from it in the first place. There are just two basic requirements that your table needs to meet—at least one of your columns should have lots of repeated values (like City or Salespeople

in our sample case) and numerical data. The latter is the more important of the two, which is why PivotTables find themselves used more for such things as sales and financial reports.

Next, you need to ensure that the table is formatted properly:

1. Each column should have a heading
2. There shouldn't be any blank rows between

the headings and the data

3. There shouldn't be any blank rows or columns within the data; if possible, try to avoid blank cells as well

Once you've made sure of all this, your table is now pivot-worthy, or pivot-able.

	A	B	C	D	E
1	Order ID	City	Product	Units Sold	Sales
2	1	Mumbai	One	12	A
3	2	Delhi	One	22	A
4	3	Bangalore	Five	44	B
5	4	Mumbai	Seven	40	C
6	5	Bangalore	Two	23	A
7	6	Mumbai	Three	31	A
8	7	Delhi	Five	21	A
9	8	Mumbai	Seven	17	B
10	9	Bangalore	Three	60	C
11	10	Delhi	Two	31	C

Your basic sales chart

